FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

After the general election five months ago, when the mighty BJP surprised many by failing to get a majority on its own, the recent Maharashtra assembly election was the litmus test of whether its popularity was on the wane. The results dispel that notion stunningly. The party's 132-seat tally is just 13 short of a solo majority in a house of 288. Its Mahayuti alliance has 235 seats; the Opposition Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) is less than a quarter of that at 50. It is a massive boost to the BJP's morale, particularly its leadership that was quite perturbed by the general election result. As a corollary, this also ensures the loyalty of its allies, Nitish Kumar and Chandrababu Naidu. The INDIA coalition, which thought it was on the rise after the general election, has been stopped in its tracks after the Haryana and Maharashtra assembly results. Their newfound verve stands dulled.

Some masterful electoral mechanics went into the making of the magic wand-like sweep. It helped that the MVA bumbled along in the comfortable delusion that its decisive tally of 31 out of 48 seats in the Lok Sabha election, which contained 157 assembly seats, would automatically translate into a majority in the state poll. But the BJP cannily changed its game. Taking nothing for granted in what they recognised as a do-or-die battle, party strategists evolved a new playbook—a revised engineering manual, if you like. Its dual strategy of ideology and pragmatism did not flower in Jharkhand, but the bumper harvest in Maharashtra more than compensated.



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The playbook had four key components. One, learning from its mistakes, the BJP dialled down on using Modi as the be-all and end-all of a typical carpet-bombing campaign. While he did remain the mascot, instead of his personage drowning everything else, more room was given to homegrown faces. It allayed any misgivings about Maharashtra, a state high on regional pride, being swamped by the 'Delhi durbar'. This also created the right ambience for the next component: Going Local. Rather than a central command tightly controlling ticket distribution, local satraps got total tactical space. Even the allies, CM Eknath Shinde, entirely sprung from the soil, and a softened Ajit Pawar shouldered their end of the campaign. Meanwhile, the BJP's own Devendra Fadnavis pulled off a crucial backroom coup.

This was to become Step #3: the full resumption of services by the RSS. After hints of friction with the BJP top brass during the Lok Sabha election, the differences had been ironed out by the time of the Haryana polls in October, contributing to the astonishing victory there. The rapprochement was now in full force through the good offices of Nagpur boy Fadnavis. The array of RSS skills proved its worth. Its guiding hand was visible in everything from strategy to choice of candidates. At the same time, the cadre put boots on the ground to counter MVA propaganda, galvanise voters and tighten up last-mile booth management. This closing of ranks is likely to have a salutary effect in New Delhi, with greater coordination on the upcoming choice for the next BJP president.

The last step involved a retuning of politics on two fronts. Hindutva was deployed, of course, as it was valuable within the Hindu voter base to counter the disaggregating effect of caste politics in Maharashtra. Modi's relative distance from the heat and dust of battle allowed him to stay with a softer, more euphemistic slogan like '*Ek hai to safe hai* (united, we are safe)'. The brutal rhetoric like '*Batenge to katenge* (Divided, we'll be felled)' was outsourced to campaigners like Amit Shah and Yogi Adityanath. The vocabulary was in spate in Jharkhand, too, with Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma bringing his staple 'Bangladeshi infiltrators' bogey to the campaign. The expected xenophobic response was not forthcoming in that state, which is a sobering feedback the BJP could heed.

Beyond the political strategies, there's another fundamental change. Maharashtra seals the BJP's adoption of freebie economics, reversing the PM's famous stance against 'revdi culture'. The Ladki Bahin Yojana, rolled out by the Shinde government after the Lok Sabha election, saw three monthly tranches of Rs 1,500 and a double tranche for October-November combined on poll eve, go out to over 23 million women in the state. Women's turnout rose commensurately, from 59.26 per cent in 2019 to 65.22 per cent this time. With the BJP promising to increase the monthly cash transfer to Rs 2,100, their preference showed. In Jharkhand, a similar pro-women freebie, the Maiya Samman Yojana, gave Hemant Soren and his wife Kalpana a universal plank, even as they worked on Adivasi pride.

Our cover package this week looks ahead on several fronts. The lead essay casts a telescope on the emerging scenario in New Delhi as Modi returns to policymaking with renewed vigour and confidence, the sting of diminution now behind him. With the Congress flattering to deceive once again, equations will also change within the INDIA bloc. However, coalition challenges will remain in Mahayuti, with ambitions raised on all sides. The selection of the chief minister will bring its own challenges. As for Modi 3.0, electoral politics is out of the way until Delhi and Bihar vote next year. The focus must shift to economic revival. That basic handouts can win elections is not a happy development. Elections should be won on policy issues that better the lives of people permanently: the very need for doles must go.

(Aroon Purie)